

BUAD 4900 Interview Prep Workbook

STAR Bank, Technical Checklist, and Interview Reflections

Spring 2026

How to use this workbook. This is one of three workbooks for the course. Career competencies, resume, LinkedIn, and relocation planning are in the Career Development Workbook, and the weekly lab report and video reflections are in the Weekly Lab Log. The pages here are tied to the five formal practice interviews, two behavioral, two technical, and one combined final. Each page below is a reusable master template. Since this is a fillable PDF, filling a page in directly will overwrite what was there before, so save a new copy before reusing a page, for example *Technical1_Checklist.pdf*, and keep this file blank as your master.

What to wear. No need to dress up for either of the behavioral interviews or either of the technical interviews, or the combined final. You already understand the concept of dressing for a formal interview, that is not what these five sessions are testing. Come as you normally would to lab. The one exception is the informational interview, covered in the Career Development Workbook, which does call for business casual.

AI use policy. Generative AI is welcome for preparation, brainstorming, and polishing throughout this course, with one exception, the practice interviews themselves. The only place it is required is the resume, in the Career Development Workbook.

1 STAR Story Bank Worksheet

Build three to four stories you can adapt to most behavioral questions. Situation and Task set the context, Action is what you specifically did, Result is the outcome, and Reflection is what you took away. Fill this out once, then revise it after each behavioral practice interview.

Understanding STAR

Behavioral answers work best in a specific shape, so the interviewer can follow the story instead of untangling it themselves.

- **Situation:** set the scene. Where, when, who else was involved. A sentence or two, not a full backstory.
- **Task:** what you were specifically responsible for, not what the team as a whole was responsible for.
- **Action:** what you actually did. This is the longest part of the answer. Say "I," not "we," even for group work, since the interviewer wants your role specifically.
- **Result:** what happened. A number or a concrete outcome lands better than a vague one.
- **Reflection:** what you took away or would do differently. This turns a story into evidence of growth, not just a report of an event.

Common pitfalls: telling the story from the team's point of view instead of your own, skipping the result or leaving it vague, turning the story into a complaint about someone else, and rambling without following the shape so the interviewer has to work to follow along.

Worked example

Here is what a complete story looks like in this format, using a lab scenario.

EXAMPLE — Theme: Tight deadline

Situation: Our lab team had three days left before a demo, and the login feature I was responsible for was not working with the rest of the app.

Task: I needed to get authentication working against the team's shared database without breaking anyone else's code.

Action: I isolated the problem by testing my code against a local copy of the database first, found a schema mismatch, and posted in the group chat before making any changes so nobody else's work would be affected. I fixed the mismatch and added a validation check so it would not happen again.

Result: The feature was working two days before the demo, with time left to test it, and no one else's code broke.

Reflection: I learned to isolate and test changes locally before touching anything shared, and I now flag even small changes in the team chat first.

Story A

Theme (for example: conflict, tight deadline, mistake and recovery)

Situation

Task

Action

Result

Reflection

Story B

Theme

Situation

Task

Action

Result

Reflection

Story C

Theme

Situation

Task

Action

Result

Reflection

Story D

Theme

Situation

Task

Action

Result

Reflection

2 Technical Interview Prep Checklist

Work through this list before each technical practice interview. It is meant to build a habit, not to be perfect every time.

Worked example: narrating a problem out loud

This is the skill behind the "narrating my thought process" item below. Most candidates freeze here not because they cannot solve the problem, but because they have never practiced thinking out loud.

EXAMPLE — Prompt: "This form submits, but nothing is saved to the database. Walk me through how you would approach it."

"First I would check whether the form is actually reaching the server, so I would look at the network tab and confirm the request has the right data in it. If the request looks fine, I would check the server logs for an error on the save step. If there is no error at all, I would suspect the save call is not getting triggered, so I would add a log line right before it to confirm. From there I would narrow down whether it is a data problem, like a mismatched field name, or a logic problem, like a condition that is silently failing."

Notice the pattern: check the obvious thing first, form a hypothesis, test it, and narrow down from there, saying each step out loud rather than going quiet while thinking.

Before Practice Interview 1 (Week 11)

Rewatched at least one Phase 3 video from the resource guide
Can explain one piece of my own lab code out loud, start to finish
Reviewed a recent bug I fixed and can explain the fix
Practiced narrating my thought process while solving a small problem
Slept and ate before the session

One thing I want to focus on improving this round

Before Practice Interview 2 (Week 13)

Rewatched at least one Phase 3 video from the resource guide
Can explain one piece of my own lab code out loud, start to finish
Reviewed a recent bug I fixed and can explain the fix
Practiced narrating my thought process while solving a small problem
Slept and ate before the session

One thing I want to focus on improving this round

3 Post-Interview Self-Reflection

Use a fresh copy of this page after each of the five formal practice interviews.

Which interview

Date

What went well

What I want to improve before the next one

How this compared to the last practice interview

One goal for next time